

## 5. EUROPEAN HEALTH FORUM GASTEIN

—  
on the Future of Health in Europe  
25 to 28 September 2002

Parallelforum IV: Health Determinants –  
Nutrition and Food Policy

### **Too much of the wrong - Nutritional Problems in Europe**

Media Information: 27-09-2002

Mad cow disease and Creutzfeld-Jacob disease, the foot-and-mouth disease and nitrofen in turkey and cereals. The food scandals of the past years have made the Europeans very sensitive in terms of food quality. Even so, most do not seem to spend a thought on their daily eating behaviour – in contrast to the experts participating in the Parallelforum VI “Health Determinants – Nutrition and Food Policy”, of the 5<sup>th</sup> European Health Forum Gastein, Thursday, 26 September 2002.

The figures are alarming: Almost 30 per cent of the untimely deceased under the age of 65 died because of cancer, many because of high blood pressure, overweight or too high cholesterol values. “By means of a healthy nutrition, a lot of deaths could be avoided,” believes Anna Ferro-Luzzi, Director of the WHO Collaboration Centre on Nutrition in Rome. Actually a hundred times more people die because of malnutrition than because of intoxicated food, confirmed Camilla Sandvik of the University of Oslo, who was working for the European Commission on this issue until the end of August.

#### **Not only a problem of developing countries**

Europeans lack the consciousness that nutrition is a problem in highly developed countries. “Unhealthy nutrition and the resulting illnesses are a burdens – not only for developing countries,” declared Karen Lock of the London School of Hygiene and Tropical Medicine. The scientist currently does research for the World Health Organization (WHO) to gain data on the global burden due to nutrition based diseases. Contrarily to a former research report, the first “WHO Global Burden of Disease Study” (1990), Lock and her colleagues have split the risk factor “wrong nutrition” into a number of sub-categories. By means of categories, like low fruit and vegetable consumption, obesity or underweight the researchers gained much more detailed and valuable data than their predecessors. In four weeks the study is going to be published. An astonishing detail Lock gave away already in Gastein: “The lacking



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